the western side of the Ghats, had set up a waste rubber processing unit that gave out unbearable stench. He had to be moved out. Seshan, this time too, was not enthusiastic.

'Why do you want to evict the waste rubber processing plant when it is on the other side of the hill,' Seshan asked.

I told him the smell was unbearable and our workers and scientists have to wear masks at work.

'We can acquire the land if we need it, but the smell as a reason doesn't cut ice,' said Seshan.

I changed tact.

'We need the land.'

'For what?'

'For a cryogenic propulsion plant,' I lied.

'But you don't have a cryogenic engine,' Seshan retorted.

'What do we do when we have one? We can't create a hill and a valley so conducive for the plant. When we have the opportunity, we have to make the most of it. And yes, we will soon be testing cryogenic engines.'

When I finished saying this, I realised that I was not lying, only thinking aloud. It is another matter that ISRO got into cryogenics in the early 1990s with me at the helm, after a two-decade delay caused by the ISRO spy case and the following dip in scientist morale, and successfully established the liquid hydrogen plant here. We still do it in Mahendragiri.

Seshan agreed.

I knew Kurien was so influential that he would get information of any move we made at the earliest stage and would preempt acquisition. We decided to act swift and silent. Seshan got the PMO to write a confidential letter to Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M G Ramachandran (MGR) saying the land has to be annexed to the ISRO facility, and the state has to do it immediately, treating it as a matter of national importance.

'National importance.' Those words carried weight—and some immunity while taking possession of the land in what could be called Operation Thunderstorm. MGR deputed a minister to provide all support, and assigned the Armed Reserve Police to accompany the district officials